

The 7-Question Coaching Conversation



My framework for managers who want to stop solving problems for their team.

"If you don't have a goal for your conversation, you're chit-chatting."

— From a coaching session

Seven questions. One shift.

Most leaders are exceptional individual contributors who never learned to coach. They were promoted for having answers. Coaching requires the opposite muscle: holding space for someone else's answer to emerge.

These seven questions are the entry point. Used in order, in your next one-on-one, they will surface a different conversation than the one you're used to having.

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Best read with a notebook within reach. Try one question this week.

Coaching is a craft, not a concept.

Read each question slowly. The framework name underneath tells you the underlying principle — what it teaches isn't the question itself, but the posture the question creates.

In your next coaching conversation, choose ONE question. Just one. Notice what changes — in the room, in the silence between you, in what your team member says next.

These questions are not a checklist. They are a doorway. The door opens when you stop solving and start asking.

"You see them whole and complete, naturally resourceful and creative. The questions are how you treat them that way."

OI

What is the goal of this conversation?

Goal-then-conversation

Every coaching conversation has a goal. Without a declared outcome, the conversation belongs to whoever talks loudest. The goal is not yours as the coach — it belongs entirely to the person sitting across from you. Your job is to draw it out before a single piece of content is exchanged.

Most managers walk into a one-on-one with no anchor. The default opening is 'how's it going?' — which invites whatever is most pressing to the team member that day, not necessarily what's most valuable. The conversation drifts. Thirty minutes later, both people leave without a clear picture of what changed.

Open with the goal. Before anything else — before any status update or problem lands on the table — ask: 'What would you like to walk out of this conversation having clarity on?' That question shifts ownership immediately. The team member is no longer a passenger. They are the author of the session.

"Every conversation has a goal. If you don't have one, you're chit-chatting."

TRY THIS IN YOUR NEXT 1-ON-1

Open your next one-on-one with: 'Before we start — what would you like to walk out of this conversation with?' Wait for them to answer fully. Don't suggest. Don't lead. Let them set the agenda.

02

Which hat am I wearing right now?

Hat-switching

Leaders carry multiple roles into any conversation: the operational leader who owns outcomes, the mentor who has been down this road, the owner who protects the bottom line. Each hat comes with a built-in agenda. Coaching requires you to put every one of those hats down deliberately — and pick up the only hat that makes coaching possible: the coach's hat.

Most leaders walk into a coaching conversation still wearing the leader-hat. They reflexively evaluate ('that approach won't scale'), instruct ('what you should do is'), or mentor ('when I was in your position'). Their intentions are good. Their hats are in the way. The moment evaluation enters the room, psychological safety leaves.

Name the switch out loud — at least internally. Before walking into the room, before the calendar invite opens, pause and say: 'I'm taking off my leader hat, my mentor hat, my owner hat. For the next twenty minutes, I'm coming in with a coach's hat on.' That thirty-second ritual changes the quality of every question that follows.

"I'm gonna take off my leader hat or my mentor hat or my owner hat — and come in with a coach's hat on."

TRY THIS IN YOUR NEXT 1-ON-1

Before your next one-on-one, sit at your desk for 30 seconds and name which hat you're putting down. Say it out loud: 'I am taking off my leader hat for the next twenty minutes.' The verbalization matters.

03

Am I listening 70-80% of the time?

70/30 Listening Rule

70 to 80 percent of any coaching conversation is listening — actively, with both ears, without rehearsing your next response. The other 20 to 30 percent is asking reflective questions and acknowledging what surfaces. If your speaking-to-listening ratio creeps anywhere close to 50/50, you are not coaching anymore. You are mentoring, facilitating, or presenting. The focus of the coach is two things only: actively listen, and ask reflective questions.

The default is to fill silence. A team member pauses to think, and most managers — especially the high-performers — rush in with a clarifying question, a reframe, or worse, an answer. Their internal monologue is 'I should help them think.' But the help is the obstacle. The pause is where the thinking is happening.

Treat silence as data. The pause is where insight is forming. Put it sharply: what you'd say in those three seconds is rarely as valuable as what they'd say in those ten. The discipline is to count to ten in your head, watch their face, and let them surface the next sentence themselves. When you do speak, it's to ask one reflective question — not to solve, not to mentor, not to fill space.

"What you'd say in those three seconds is rarely as valuable as what they'd say in those ten."

TRY THIS IN YOUR NEXT 1-ON-1

When they pause, count silently to ten before you speak. Don't rephrase. Don't redirect. Just count. Then ask one reflective question: 'What else?'

04

What's the question underneath the question?

The question underneath the question

Most surface questions hide a deeper one. A team member asks about a process problem, but underneath that is a question about trust. They ask about a deliverable, but underneath that is a question about capability. Coaching surfaces the question they actually came to ask — the one they haven't yet found the words for.

Most managers take the surface question literally. They answer it, solve it, move on. The team member leaves with a tactical response but no resolution to what was actually driving the question. Two weeks later, a version of the same conversation returns. The surface keeps getting addressed; the root never does.

Reflect the question back. When a team member asks something, rather than answering immediately, ask: 'And what's the question behind that question for you?' This is the self-reflection layer — it's in the questions that people allow themselves to examine what's actually happening, what conversations they're having with themselves that they want to name and disempower.

"It's in the questions that they allow themselves to self-reflect on what's really going on."

TRY THIS IN YOUR NEXT 1-ON-1

When they ask you something, pause before answering. Ask: 'What's the question behind that question for you?' Stay quiet. Let them go one layer deeper.

05

Have I suspended judgment?

Suspend judgment

Judgment is the fastest way to close the room. The moment a team member senses evaluation — a frown, a lean-forward, a 'well, but' — the psychological safety drops and the honest conversation ends. Suspending judgment is not passive tolerance; it's the active decision to approach what someone knows and believes as potentially valuable, even when it differs from your own view.

Leaders who have deep expertise in their domain find this the hardest skill to hold. They know what works. They have pattern recognition built over years. When a team member surfaces a belief that contradicts that experience, the micro-expression of evaluation happens before the leader is even aware of it. The team member reads the room, and self-censors.

Operate from the premise: 'I'm not better than you. I don't know what you know — and what you know might be valuable for the business or for the relationship. Tell me more.' That posture is not just words. It's a genuine reset of the power dynamic in the room. When a team member feels genuinely un-judged, they say the things that actually move the work forward.

"I'm not better than you. I don't know what you know."

TRY THIS IN YOUR NEXT 1-ON-1

When you feel a judgment forming, name it silently to yourself: 'I'm about to evaluate.' Then ask one more open question instead. 'Tell me more about how you arrived at that.'

06

Did I acknowledge and validate them?

Acknowledge & validate

People want to be acknowledged. They want to be validated. There is effort in answering your questions — real cognitive and emotional effort in the self-examination that good coaching requires. The close of any coaching conversation should name that effort explicitly. Not generically. Specifically: what they brought, what they worked through, what shifted.

Most managers end a coaching conversation on the action item. 'Great, so you'll do X by Friday — good chat, see you next week.' The functional box is checked. But the human dimension of the conversation — the moment the team member went somewhere uncomfortable and came back with something real — goes unacknowledged. That gap accumulates over months into a team that stops taking risks in their conversations with you.

Close with acknowledgment before closing with action. The language matters here: every word should point to **them**, not back to the coach. The acknowledgment sounds like: 'Honoring the way you showed up with courage and honesty during this conversation. Your share and reflective insight showed how open and accepting you are to seeing a way forward.' For validating the feelings underneath: 'It is understandable to feel the way you feel about the situation.' This is one of the non-negotiables of every session — the team member leaves feeling that the effort they brought was seen, and that the acknowledgment was about them, not about the coach.

"People want to be acknowledged. They want to be validated. There's effort in answering your questions."

TRY THIS IN YOUR NEXT 1-ON-1

Close your next one-on-one with this acknowledgment: 'Honoring the way you showed up — [name the specific thing they did, e.g., the honesty when discussing the team conflict, the willingness to sit with a hard question]. Your reflection showed real openness to seeing a path forward.' Notice: every word points to them. Not 'I noticed.' Not 'I want to acknowledge.' Just them.

07

What's the most important next step in 24-48 hours?

24-48 hour close

Action lives in the close. A coaching conversation that ends without a specific, time-bound, owner-named next step has produced insight but not momentum. The window is deliberate: 24 to 48 hours. Not 'sometime this week.' Not 'by next month.' The shorter the gap between the insight and the action, the higher the follow-through.

The most common close is 'let me know how it goes.' That sentence transfers zero accountability. There is no action, no timeline, no named owner, and no agreed-upon definition of what 'it goes' even means. The conversation dissolves into the week and the insight with it. You've had a good talk. You have not had a coaching session.

Ask the question directly: 'What's the most important next step you're going to take in the next 24 to 48 hours?' Then wait. Don't suggest. Don't prompt. The team member names the step, the timeline, and the ownership — in their own words. That specificity is what converts a conversation into a commitment.

"Action lives in the close. Without it, you've had a conversation, not a coaching session."

TRY THIS IN YOUR NEXT 1-ON-1

End your next coaching conversation with literally this: 'What's the most important next step you're going to take in the next 24 to 48 hours?' Wait for them to answer. Do not suggest.

One conversation, seven moments.

- 01** → *Set the goal* → "What do you want to walk out with?"
 - 02** → *Take off the hat* → Choose curiosity, not evaluation
 - 03** → *Listen 70-80%* → Count to ten before you fill silence
 - 04** → *Ask underneath* → "What's the question behind that?"
 - 05** → *Suspend judgment* → "I don't know what you know."
 - 06** → *Acknowledge* → "Honoring the way you showed up — [moment]."
 - 07** → *Close with 24-48* → "What's your most important next step?"
-

In order, this becomes a structure. Out of order, it's still better than chit-chatting.

You can use these seven questions tomorrow.

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“I’m on a mission to raise a million coaches. Every leader who steps in raises the next ten.”

— Coach Gina

A handwritten signature in black ink that reads "X, Gina". The "X" is a simple cross, and "Gina" is written in a cursive, flowing script.